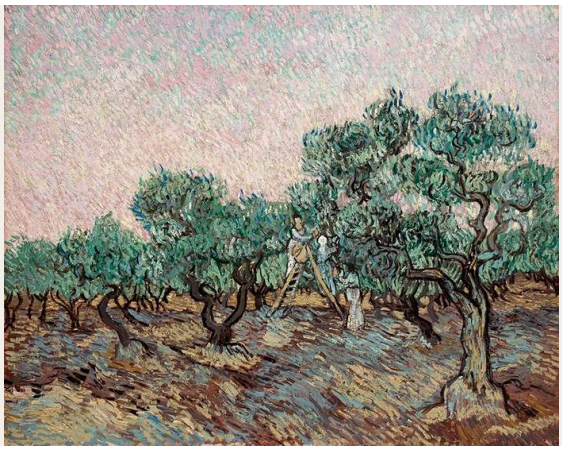
ATHENS, GREECE

Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation: Masterpieces

Twenty paintings in which marks and shapes remain visible inside the things they describe.



Van Gogh's coffee pot is emphatically blue, Cézanne's countryside is assembled through patches, and Monet's cathedral begins to lose the solidity expected of stone. These works do not abandon recognisable subjects. They make it difficult to forget that a subject has been constructed in paint.

The Goulandris selection also includes pictures in which recognition becomes less secure. A few lines sustain a head; a title proposes an insect; an architectural fragment finds itself beside rearing horses. Rather than asking which works are “realistic,” follow the different amounts of information needed to identify something. A plain glass and an imaginary body can both reveal how much pictorial conviction depends on the relation between a shape and its surroundings.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/goulandris-athens

The selection · 20

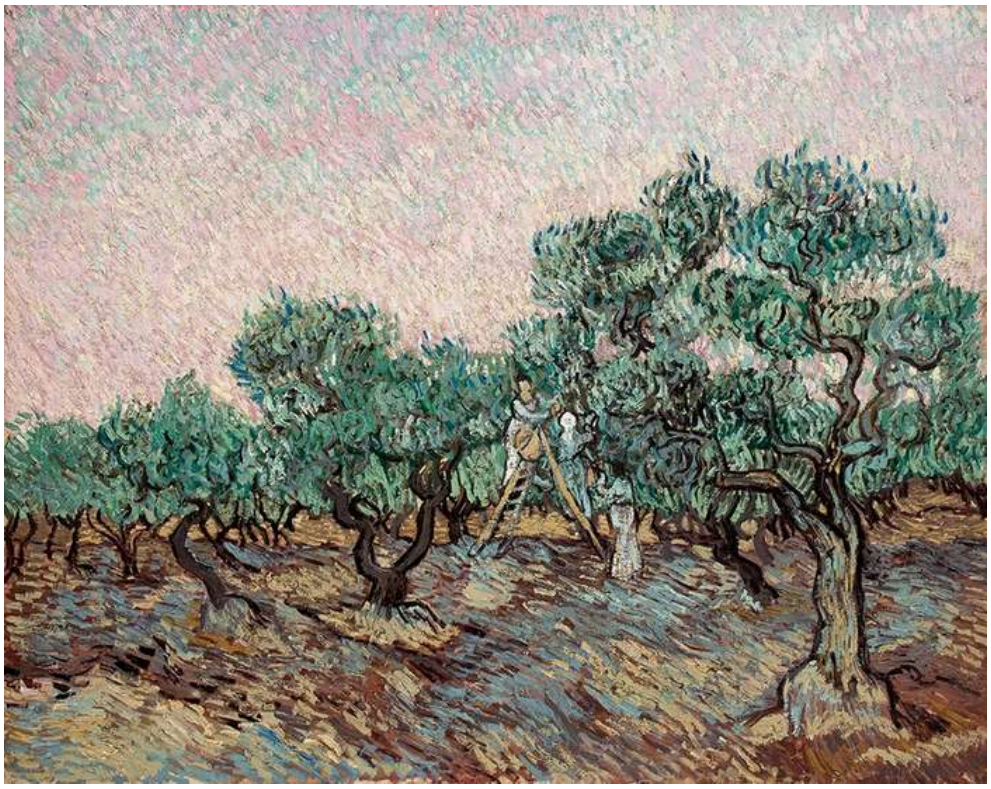
1. Olive Picking
   Vincent van Gogh · December 1889
2. Still Life with a Coffee Pot
   Vincent van Gogh · May 1888
3. Both Striped
   Wassily Kandinsky · 1932
4. Dynamics of a Head
   Paul Klee · 1934
5. Rouen Cathedral in the Morning: Pink Dominant
   Claude Monet · 1894
6. The Grasshopper
   Joan Miró · 1926
7. Archaic Landscape
   Theodoros Stamos · 1947
8. Balcony with Horizontal Pilasters
   Nikos Hadjikyriakos-Ghika · 1954
9. Caryatid
   Amedeo Modigliani · c. 1914
10. Countryside in Auvers-sur-Oise
    Paul Cézanne · 1881-1882
11. Getting Out of the Bath
    Pierre Bonnard · c. 1926-1930
12. Glass with Water
    Jean Fautrier · 1947
13. Harmony
    Constantinos Parthenis · 1930
14. Head of a Hostage No. 17
    Jean Fautrier · 1944
15. Horses on the Beach
    Giorgio de Chirico · c. 1930
16. Italian Town
    André Derain · 1936
17. Man in an Interior
    Victor Brauner · 1937
18. Mechanical Element
    Fernand Léger · 1919
19. Ninety-nine Heads
    Friedensreich Hundertwasser · June-August 1952
20. Nude
    André Derain · c. 1948-1950

01 / 20

Olive Picking

Vincent van Gogh

December 1889 · Oil on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



Vincent van Gogh (1853 - 1890); Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation · Copyright © 2026 Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation; Copyright © 2026 Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation; Terms of Use & Privacy Policy Financial information

The workers' movements belong to a grove already active with short strokes and twisting trunks. Van Gogh does not separate human labour from a quietly neutral landscape. Trees, soil and figures share a restless handling, while differences of shape keep the workers identifiable. The picture's movement comes from both the represented task and the marks connecting its setting.

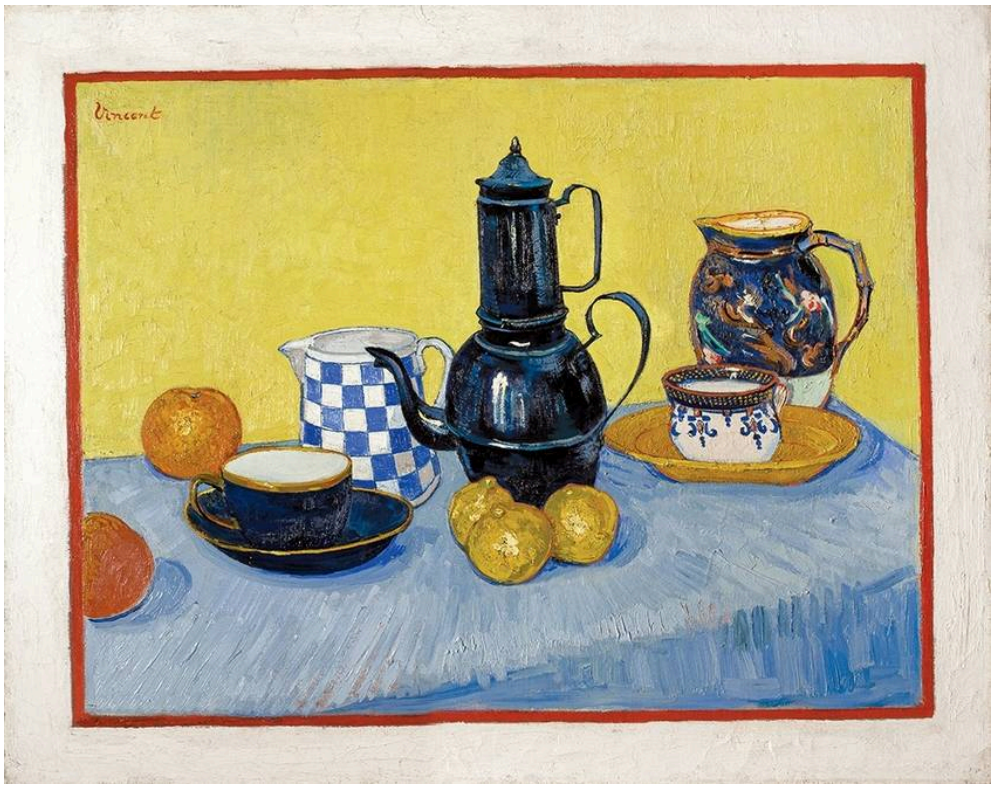
Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Still Life with a Coffee Pot

Vincent van Gogh

May 1888 · Oil on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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The blue pot stands firmly against yellow, but the smaller objects introduce a changing set of patterns and contours around it. Van Gogh uses ordinary vessels as partners in a colour arrangement. Their familiarity makes the departures easy to follow: a cup remains a cup while its outline and shadow become forceful elements in the surface.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Both Striped

Wassily Kandinsky

1932 · Oil and gouache on board · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



Wassily Kandinsky (1866 - 1944); Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation · Copyright © 2026 Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation; Copyright © 2026 Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation; Terms of Use & Privacy Policy Financial information

The two large forms seem related before they can be identified as anything. Repeated bands connect them, while differences of direction and scale prevent them from becoming twins. Kandinsky gives them a field of smaller arcs and rectangles in which to act. Interaction can be suggested through position without supplying characters or an illustrated event.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Dynamics of a Head

Paul Klee

1934 · Oil on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



Paul Klee (1879 - 1940); Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation · Copyright © 2026 Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation; Copyright © 2026 Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation; Terms of Use & Privacy Policy Financial information

The pale circles provide a foothold for reading eyes within overlapping colour. Once a face emerges, its surrounding bands remain visibly independent shapes. Klee keeps both accounts available. The image is more structured than an arbitrary collection of patches, yet less settled than a conventional likeness; its activity lies in moving between those readings.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Rouen Cathedral in the Morning: Pink Dominant

Claude Monet

1894 · Oil on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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Dark openings preserve the façade's divisions within pink and violet marks. Stone has not vanished, but its painted appearance depends on conditions that stone itself does not control. Monet makes architecture and illumination difficult to separate. The building supplies a repeated structure through which slight changes of colour can become the main incident.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

The Grasshopper

Joan Miró

1926 · Oil on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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The title offers a creature before the sparse signs supply a straightforward body. Thin lines and small coloured forms spread across yellow, interrupted by a dark lower shape. Miró leaves recognition partial. Treating every mark as an insect part would make the picture less open than its actual arrangement, in which signs can suggest life without illustrating anatomy.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Archaic Landscape

Theodoros Stamos

1947 · Oil on hardboard · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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Fragments and pool-like shapes suggest terrain without fixing a scale. Stamos's textured brown field can seem close and material, while its scattered forms invite a broader landscape reading. The blue area near the bottom introduces another kind of surface. The painting can evoke accumulated matter without becoming a map of an identifiable place.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Balcony with Horizontal Pilasters

Nikos Hadjikyriakos-Ghika

1954 · Oil on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



Nikos Hadjikyriakos-Ghika (1906 - 1994); Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation · Copyright © 2026 Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation; Copyright © 2026 Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation; Terms of Use & Privacy Policy Financial information

The balcony supplies an architectural starting point for bands, grids and curved forms that no longer obey one viewpoint. Hadjikyriakos-Ghika gives small decorative details a place inside larger divisions. The structure is read through repetition and interlocking surfaces. Architecture becomes available for rearrangement rather than serving only as something faithfully viewed from outside.

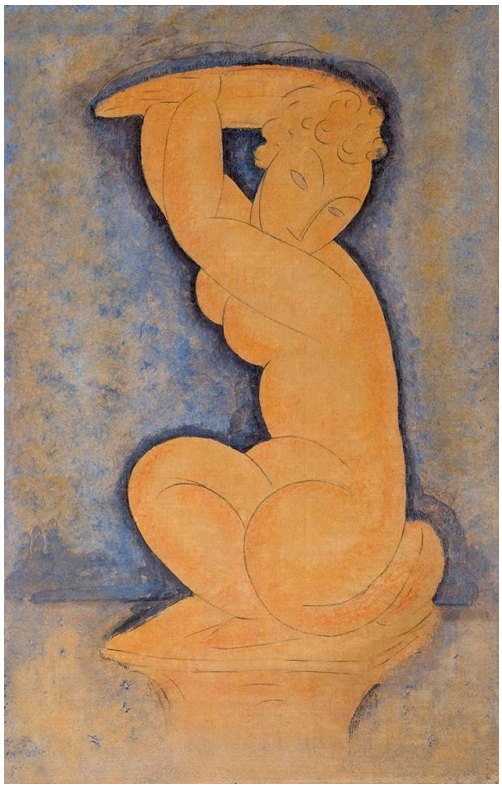
Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Caryatid

Amedeo Modigliani

c. 1914 · Pencil and gouache on paper laid down on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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Raised arms make the kneeling figure resemble a support even though no building rests above her. Modigliani simplifies joints into broad curves, giving the body a compact relation of bearing and balance. The architectural title changes how the pose is read. A human form can imply a load through its organisation before the load is actually shown.

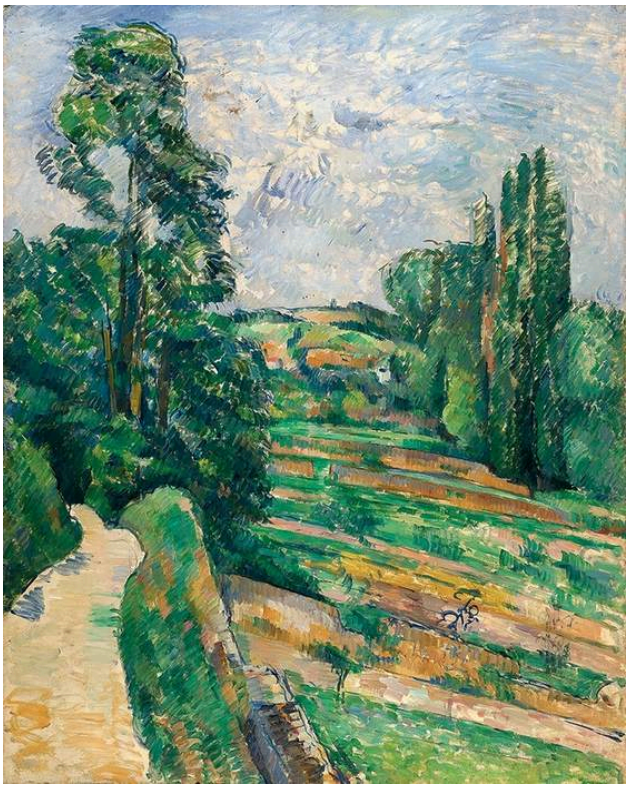
Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Countryside in Auvers-sur-Oise

Paul Cézanne

1881-1882 · Oil on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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The road and slopes establish distance, while repeated green and ochre strokes keep their construction visible. Cézanne's tall trees frame a landscape whose solidity comes from adjoining patches rather than smooth continuous shading. The eye can follow a route towards the houses and also stop at the local relations of colour that make that route possible.

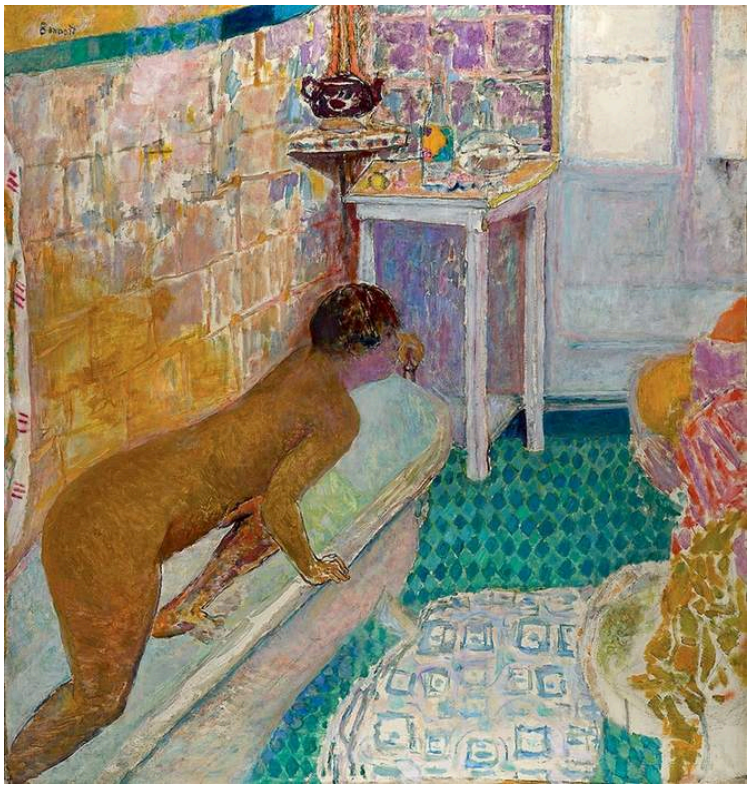
Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Getting Out of the Bath

Pierre Bonnard

c. 1926-1930 · Oil on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



Pierre Bonnard (1867 - 1947); Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation · Copyright © 2026 Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation; Copyright © 2026 Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation; Terms of Use & Privacy Policy Financial information

Patterned tiles, fixtures and fabrics compete with the bending figure. Bonnard makes a recognisable private action harder to isolate because so much of the room remains active in colour. The body must be found among those surfaces. Its partial entanglement with the setting distinguishes this picture from a figure simply placed against a decorative background.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

Glass with Water

Jean Fautrier

1947 · Mixed media on paper laid down on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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The glass is identifiable, but the rough painted field refuses to imitate its expected smoothness. Thin ridges and thicker matter maintain an outline without producing an illusion of pure transparency. Fautrier places two material facts in tension: the vessel the image represents and the worked surface through which it becomes visible.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

Harmony

Constantinos Parthenis

1930 · Oil on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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Long bodies are lightly distinguished from the pale field around them. Parthenis reduces the sense of flesh and a definite location, allowing curved outlines to carry relations between the figures. The allegorical title does not correspond to a single easily named action. The image's coherence has to be followed through these restrained connections.

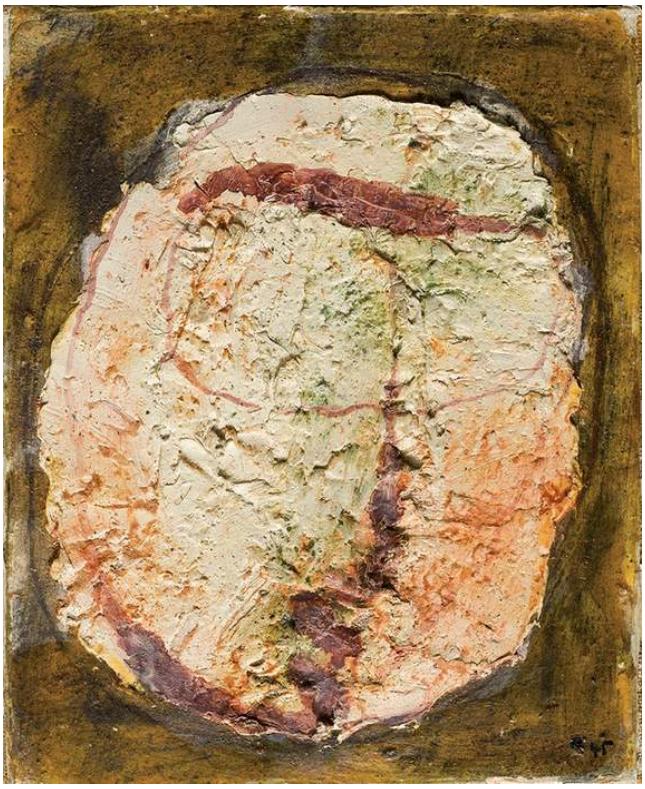
Object source · Open artwork

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Head of a Hostage No. 17

Jean Fautrier

1944 · Mixed media on paper laid down on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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A pale oval and a few marked features barely sustain a face against the rough ground. The word “hostage” prevents that reduction from remaining a purely formal exercise. Fautrier brings a human subject close to the limit of recognition, using damaged-looking matter rather than a descriptive scene of violence. The title and surface must be considered together.

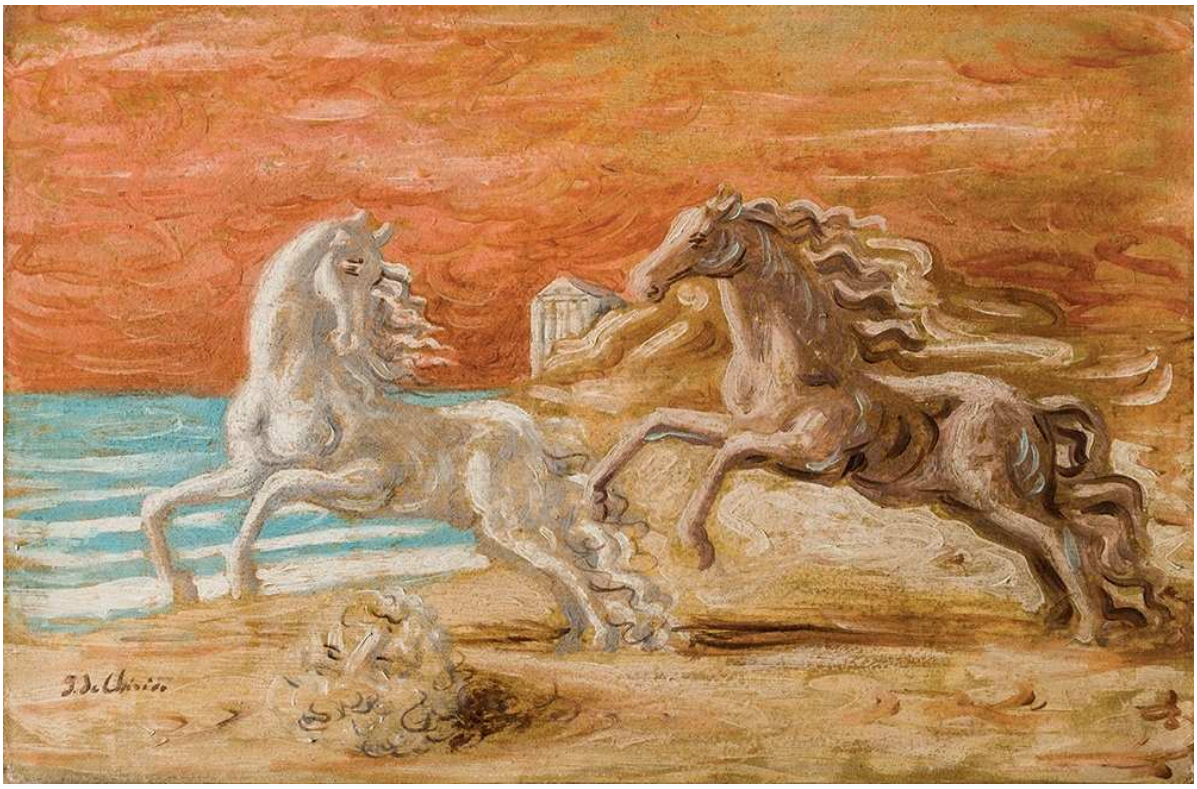
Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Horses on the Beach

Giorgio de Chirico

c. 1930 · Oil on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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The rearing horses supply movement within an otherwise strangely settled combination of beach and architectural fragments. De Chirico keeps the individual things legible while withholding an ordinary explanation of their coexistence. Recognition does not resolve the scene. Knowing what a horse or a fragment is leaves open why they share this precisely presented place.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Italian Town

André Derain

1936 · Gouache on board laid down on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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The broad square has little activity to distract from the intervals between its buildings. Sharply bounded façades and small clouds preserve the clarity of the arrangement beneath the large sky. Derain gives urban space a subject without a dominant event. Its near-emptiness makes proportion and separation unusually consequential.

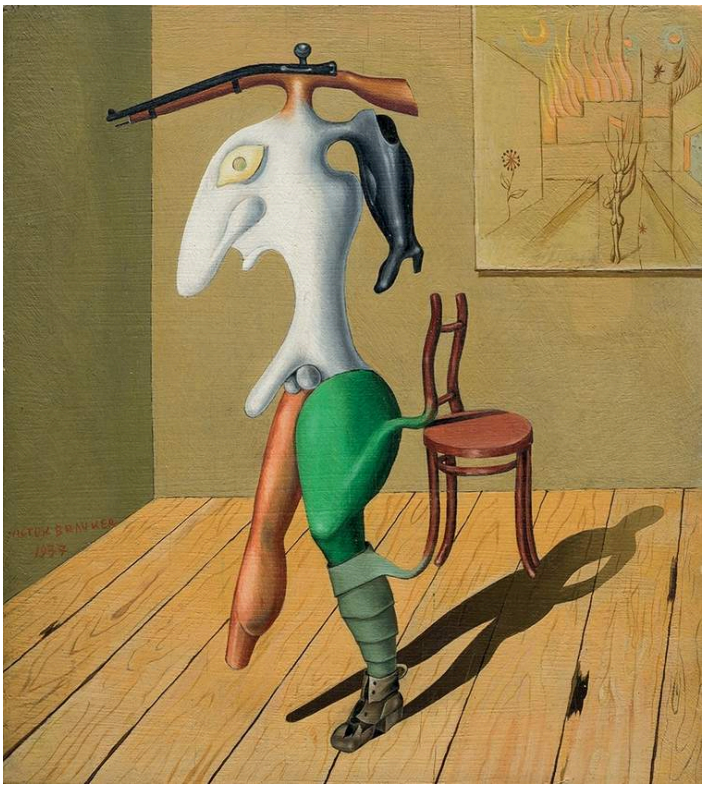
Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

Man in an Interior

Victor Brauner

1937 · Oil on panel · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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The chair, floor and shadow behave more ordinarily than the upright figure beside them. Brauner uses that familiar evidence of a room to make an impossible combination of bodily and object-like parts appear to occupy space. The contradiction is sharpened by its setting. A less plausible environment would give the figure less resistance against which to seem strange.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Mechanical Element

Fernand Léger

1919 · Oil on canvas · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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Tubes, discs and bands suggest machinery without explaining a mechanism. Léger extracts relations of curve, overlap and contrast from components associated with practical use. Their organisation is clear even though no operating sequence can be reconstructed. The picture asks what machine forms can do visually once they are released from the obligation to work together mechanically.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Ninety-nine Heads

Friedensreich Hundertwasser

June-August 1952 · Oil on hard fibre board primed with chalk, zinc white and fish glue, with photo affixed and lilac watercolour · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



Friedensreich Hundertwasser (1928 - 2000); Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation · Copyright © 2026 Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation; © 2023 NAMIDA AG, Glarus, Switzerland, All Rights Reserved; Copyright © 2026 Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation; Terms of Use & Privacy Policy Financial information

Faces accumulate across the red field, often within smaller coloured compartments. Differences of size interrupt the repeated format, with larger eyes disrupting any regular count. Hundertwasser gives each head enough information to remain readable while allowing the group to spread as a pattern. Repetition creates company here without producing uniform scale or orderly ranks.

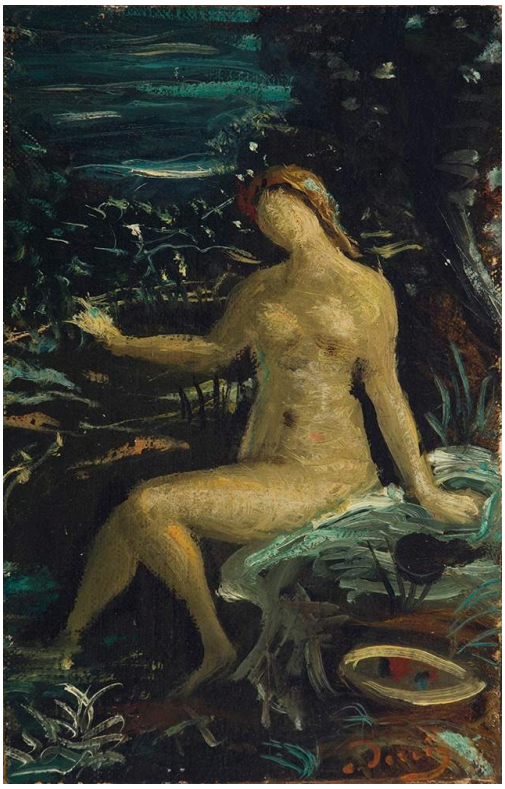
Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Nude

André Derain

c. 1948-1950 · Oil on canvas laid down on cradled panel · Basil & Elise Goulandris Foundation



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Pale areas distinguish the torso within dark foliage and rough curved marks. Derain lets the body's handling share something with the surrounding vegetation, but the extended arm and seated pose preserve a separate figure. The image does not require a clear studio boundary to give the body weight. Its distinction from the landscape remains partial and worked for.

Object source · Open artwork

Keep two readings available

Choose a recognisable object and follow the marks that make it. Then look at a more abstract work without immediately demanding names for all its forms. These are comparisons within the collection; consult the Foundation's current display information for a visit.

Further reading

Concerning the Spiritual in Art

Wassily Kandinsky; translated by Michael Sadleir · Read free · English

Kandinsky argues that colour and form can act without copying visible objects. His text offers a direct companion to Both Striped and a point of comparison with Klee, Léger and the more material surfaces of Fautrier.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12